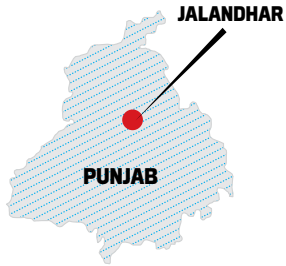


MANN ON THE MOVE The Punjab CM during a roadshow shortly before AAP candidate S.K. Rinku files nomination

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LOK SABHA BYPOLL

BATTLE FOR JALANDHAR



By Anilesh S. Mahajan

On April 17, amid thousands of workers from across north India beating dhols and singing some signature revolutionary songs, Punjab chief minister Bhagwant Mann led his star-studded caravan to file the nomination papers of the Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) candidate Sushil Kumar Rinku for the bypolls to the Jalandhar parliamentary seat on May 10. Accompanying him were Rajya Sabha MP Ashok Mittal, state finance minister Harpal Cheema, local MLAs Sheetal Aungral, Balkar Singh, Inderjeet Mann and Raman Arora alongside two trophy recruits—Mohinder Bhagat, formerly of the BJP, and Jagbir Brar, who is ex-Akali Dal. All this, to project themselves as the dominant player in the constituency. Both AAP and Mann are desperate to restore the sheen of their spectacular win in 2022, which has been marred in some measure by the impression that Arvind Kejriwal is ruling by proxy, that Mann's governance is ineffective and he is unable to control the spiralling radicalisation. The Amritpal Singh saga, in particular, has not left the administration covered in glory.

Jalandhar is a reserved constituency for Dalits, where the bypoll has been necessitated by the demise of the two-time Lok Sabha member Chaudhary Santokh Singh in January. Traditionally a Congress bastion, the party has lost the seat just four times, twice each to Akali Dal and the Janata Dal. In the 2022 state elections, amid the AAP wave, the Congress managed to win five of the nine assembly segments in Jalandhar, while the AAP won four. This time, the Congress has fielded Santokh's widow Karamjit Kaur Chaudhary, who is seeking the sympathy vote for her departed husband. The party is backing her fully, both to retain the seat as well as in the hope that it could lay the foundation for its revival in the state. Pratap Singh Bajwa, the leader of the Opposition in the assembly, is anchoring the campaign.

AAP, on the other hand, is relying heavily on turncoats. Their candidate Rinku, in fact, joined the party days before filing his papers. He had contested in 2022 from Jalandhar West on a Congress ticket. AAP also engineered defections in the Akali Dal to pull out Brar (Jalandhar Cantt), and in the BJP, by luring Mohinder Bhagat (Jalandhar West). AAP also tried to dent Congress chances by enlisting Surinder Chaudhary, nephew of Santokh Chaudhary and the party's leader in the Kartarpur assembly segment, but Bajwa intervened and Surinder was back with the Congress within five days.

UNLIKE IN THE PAST, THE BYPOLL WILL NOT BE A BIPOLAR CONTEST BUT A FIVE-CORNERED ONE, WITH EACH SIDE PUTTING ITS MIGHT

Both AAP and the Congress know they are in for a tough battle. Unlike the past, it will not be a bipolar contest but a five-cornered one. While the Akali Dal has fielded Sukhwinder Kumar, its sitting MLA from Banga, the BJP has placed its bets on Akali turncoat Inder Iqbal Atwal. And after the victory in Sangrur Lok Sabha bypoll in June last year, no one can take Simranjit Singh Mann's SAD (Amritsar) lightly. He's fielding confidant Gurjant Singh Kattu.

Unlike the predominantly rural Malwa belt, which is dominated by the Jat Sikhs, Jalandhar has a sizeable Dalit population in both rural and urban areas—of the 1,669,098 voters in the 2022 election, 42.7 per cent were Dalits. They and the upper-caste Hindus determine the course of any electoral battle. In order to cash in on Dalit sentiments, the Congress has roped in former CM Charanjit Channi—the state's only Dalit CM—who is playing the victim card by saying that he has been the target